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# The Indian Home Renovation Playbook

## Quote, contract and site control for the biggest spend most families make without a rulebook

A working system for the biggest spend most families make without one: pick the right scope, price it line by line, hire and verify a contractor, sign a contract that holds, read a quote like a professional, specify materials that survive an Indian monsoon, run the site week by week, and recover your money when it goes wrong.

| 40 | 31 | 6 | 40 |
|---|---|---|---|
| PAGES | CHAPTERS | WORKSHEETS | ANSWERS |

Verified against the GST Council's September 2025 rate decisions, the Income Tax Department's house-property rules, the Consumer Protection Act 2019 and its 2021 jurisdiction rules, and the construction and demolition waste rules in force from 1 April 2026. October 2026.

# How to use this playbook

Read Part 1 and Part 2 before you call a single contractor. That is where the money is decided. A homeowner who fixes the scope and builds the budget before the first site visit saves more than any negotiation later, because the cheapest stage of a renovation is the one where nothing has been bought yet.

Parts 3 to 5 are the working core. Part 3 is about choosing and checking the people who will hold your keys. Part 4 is about the two documents that decide almost every dispute — the contract and the bill of quantities. Part 5 is a specification guide, written as questions you ask, because the difference between a bathroom that lasts fifteen years and one that leaks in two is a handful of material decisions nobody explains to you.

Part 6 is the site itself: the order of work, the points where you must be present, the arithmetic to check deliveries, and the handover. Part 7 is what to do when it goes wrong, including the route through the consumer commission and what a complainant needs to have kept. Part 8 is six printable worksheets you can fill in by hand.

**What this book is not**

It is not a price list. Published Indian rates for 2026 run from roughly Rs. 500 to Rs. 4,500 per square foot for what people call "renovation", and the spread is scope, not geography. Chapter 4 teaches you to build your own number from three quotes instead of trusting a benchmark.

It is not legal or tax advice for your specific case. It tells you which rules exist, what they say, and which questions to put to a chartered accountant or a lawyer before you sign.

It is not a design book. There are no mood boards here. This is the operating manual for the part of a renovation that costs money and causes disputes.

# The ten rules this book keeps returning to

A renovation is not a design problem that turns into a money problem. It is a money problem that occasionally looks like a design problem. These ten rules are the whole book in one page, and every one of them is cheaper to follow before work starts than after.

1. Write the scope before you ask for a price. A verbal estimate is not a price, it is an opening position.
2. Never compare per-square-foot rates. Convert every quote into the same line-item bill of quantities first.
3. Insist on carpet area in writing, and check which area the rate multiplies.
4. Assume ten to fifteen per cent of your budget will be spent on things found behind walls. Keep it separate and do not spend it on upgrades.
5. Verify the GST number, the Udyam registration and the EPFO cover before you pay an advance. All three are free to check.
6. Structure payments on completed work, never on dates. Hold back a final instalment until the snag list is closed.
7. Price every variation in writing, at the quoted rate, before the work is done.
8. Do not pay two lakh rupees or more in cash in one transaction. The penalty for the person receiving it is one hundred per cent of the amount.
9. Photograph everything, keep every invoice, and put every promise in a message you can retrieve. The consumer commission route turns on documents.
10. Nothing goes on site that you have not seen a sample of, in your own light.

**If you do only three things**

Write the scope with its exclusions, and get three itemised bills of quantities for that identical scope. This one habit removes most of the money risk in the project, because it removes the ambiguity a contractor prices against.

Structure payment on completed work and hold back five to ten per cent until the snag list is closed. Your only real leverage in a renovation is money not yet paid.

Keep the paper. The contract, the BOQ, the invoices, the photographs, the messages. Every route in Part Seven depends on documents, and the homeowner with documents wins.

# Contents

**Parts 1 to 7 are the system. Part 8 is the paperwork you carry to site.**

**How to use this playbook** 2

**The ten rules this book keeps returning to** 3

**Contents** 4

**1. Five scopes, and only one of them is yours** 7

**2. The scope statement that ends half the arguments** 8

The thirty-day countdown before anyone lifts a hammer . . . . . 8

**3. Refresh, renovate or move: the decision before the design** 9

**4. Build your own estimate from three quotes** 10

**5. The eleven costs nobody puts in the first budget** 11

**6. GST, TDS and the tax rules that surprise homeowners** 12

GST on the work itself . . . . . 12

The home loan trap that catches almost everyone . . . . . 12

Cash, and the two lakh line . . . . . 12

TDS, if your project is large . . . . . 12

**7. Paying for it without paying for it twice** 13

**8. Four ways to buy the work** 14

**9. Verify in one hour, for free** 15

**10. The reference call that actually works** 15

**11. Design fees, and what supervision buys** 16

**12. Sixteen clauses a renovation contract needs** 17

**13. Interrogating a quote: twenty questions** 18

**14. Payment: the schedule that protects you** **19**

**15. Variations: the one-page rule** **19**

**16. The render that was approved, and the room that arrived** **20**

**17. Civil work: cement, steel, sand, plaster** **21**

**18. Floors and walls: tiles, stone, adhesives** **22**

**19. Joinery: plywood, laminates, hardware** **22**

**20. Electrical and plumbing: the invisible half** **22**

**21. Waterproofing, ceilings, paint** **23**

**22. The clause that costs you the specification** **23**

**23. The order of work, and the five points where you must be present** **25**

The society, the neighbours and the three letters nobody sends . . . . . 25

**24. Check the quantities yourself** **26**

**25. The snag list, and how to close it** **26**

**26. The handover folder** **27**

The first month after you move in . . . . . 27

**27. The escalation ladder** **29**

**28. The consumer commission route, precisely** **29**

**29. Cheques, arbitration, and the notices that work** **30**

**30. The kitchen, decided in centimetres** **32**

**31. The bathroom, where water always wins** **33**

**W1. The estimate and budget sheet** **34**

**W2. The contractor scorecard** **35**

**W3. Comparing three quotes honestly** **35**

**W4. Payment tracker** **36**

**W5. Snag list** **36**

**W6. Handover checklist** **37**

**40 questions homeowners actually ask** **38**

Sources this playbook relies on . . . . . 40

PART ONE

# Decide what you are actually buying

Four out of five renovation arguments are scope arguments wearing a price costume. Two families comparing quotes of twelve lakh and twenty lakh for the same flat are usually not comparing contractors at all — they are comparing a kitchen-and-bathroom refresh against a strip-to-slab rebuild. Fix the scope first and most of the confusion disappears before money is discussed.

IN THIS PART

1 Five scopes, and only one of them is yours
2 The scope statement that ends half the arguments
3 Refresh, renovate or move: the decision before the design

## 1. Five scopes, and only one of them is yours

Indian renovation work falls into five bands. Pick one, in writing, before you invite anybody to quote. Every band below changes what stays and what goes, and that is what the price is really measuring.

| Scope | What is replaced | What stays | Disruption |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Refresh | Paint, lights, curtains, hardware, a few shutter faces | All services, floors, bathrooms, kitchen | You can live in the house |
| 2. Partial | Kitchen, one or two bathrooms, some wardrobes, repaint | Main flooring, windows, most wiring | Partial — some rooms usable |
| 3. Full interior | All joinery, all bathrooms, false ceiling, paint, lighting | Structure, wall positions, plumbing routes, flooring | Plan to move out |
| 4. Structural | Internal walls, full rewiring and replumbing, plus band 3 | Load-bearing structure and external walls | Move out; approvals needed |
| 5. Gut and rebuild | Everything inside the shell | Only columns, beams and slabs | Move out for the full programme |

The mistake almost everyone makes is drifting from band 2 into band 4 by pointing at things during site visits. Each individual instruction sounds small — move this door, shift the basin, add a point here — and nobody recalculates the total. The bill then arrives at roughly double the conversation you thought you were having.

Write the band down. Send it to every contractor in the first message. Anyone who quotes without asking which band you are in has told you something useful about how they work.

One more thing about band 4 and above. The moment an internal wall is involved, the decision stops being a taste decision and becomes a structural one. Ask the society for written permission, and get a structural engineer's opinion in writing before anyone swings a hammer. Removing what looks like a partition and turns out to be load-bearing is the single most expensive mistake available to a homeowner, and it is not covered by any warranty.

## 2. The scope statement that ends half the arguments

A scope statement is one page. It is not a design brief and it is not a contract. It is the document that stops "that was never included" from being a winning sentence in week three.

Write it in five blocks, in this order.

1. **Rooms and what happens in each.** "Kitchen: full replacement including carcass, shutters, counter, sink, chimney duct. Master bedroom: two wardrobes, no false ceiling." Room by room, not in paragraphs.
2. **The exclusions list.** This is the block most people skip and it is the most valuable. Write down what you are *not* buying: loose furniture, appliances, curtains, air conditioners, sanitaryware, light fittings, society deposits, GST. If it is not on the exclusion list and not on the inclusion list, it becomes an argument.
3. **The area, defined.** State the carpet area in square feet, and state that all rates multiply that number. Two contractors quoting on different area definitions can differ by a third without either lying.
4. **The finish level, by material.** "Vitrified tiles, Rs. 60 to Rs. 90 a square foot band, brand of my choice from your list." A finish level described as "premium" means nothing and is priced accordingly.
5. **The completion date and the working-hours constraint.** Society timings, lift restrictions, the festival weeks when labour disappears. Put them in the scope so nobody discovers them later.

> **The sentence that costs the most money in Indian renovation**
>
> “Fully finished.” Ask three contractors what it includes and you will get three different answers. One includes plumbing fittings, one does not, one quietly means only the woodwork. Replace the phrase with a list, every time you hear it.

### The thirty-day countdown before anyone lifts a hammer

Most of the damage in a renovation is done in the planning month, by omission. This is the sequence that prevents it. None of it takes long; all of it takes longer once work has started, which is why it belongs here and not later.

1. **Days 1 to 3: write the scope and the exclusions.** One page, room by room, including what you are not buying. Chapter 2.
2. **Days 3 to 5: measure and record.** Draw each room roughly to scale, write the carpet area on every page, and photograph every wall, floor and ceiling as it is today. These photographs are the only record of what was there before.
3. **Days 5 to 8: decide the fixed points.** Where the bed goes, where the wardrobe goes, where the television hangs, where the washing machine sits. Electrical points and plumbing positions flow from these, and nothing downstream is cheap to change.

4. **Days 8 to 10: talk to the society.** Get the interior work permission, the working hours, the lift and debris rules and the deposit amount in writing. Ask which weeks are blacked out for festivals or for the annual general body meeting.
5. **Days 10 to 18: get three quotes for the identical scope.** Send the same one-page scope and the same area to all three, and ask each for an itemised bill of quantities. Chapter 4.
6. **Days 18 to 22: verify and visit.** Run the five checks in Chapter 9, and visit a finished site without the contractor. Chapter 10.
7. **Days 22 to 26: build the budget.** Median rates, then contingency, GST, rent elsewhere and society charges. If the total is not fundable, cut scope now, in writing, not in week six.
8. **Days 26 to 30: sign and stage.** Contract with annexures, payment schedule, samples approved, first material ordered against your approval. Chapter 12.

# 3. Refresh, renovate or move: the decision before the design

Before you spend on a renovation, spend an hour on the honest comparison. Renovation is not always the rational answer, and it is worth knowing which case you are in before you fall in love with a kitchen.

| Situation | Usually the right move | Why |
|---|---|---|
| Home is 5 to 8 years old, everything works, it just looks tired | Band 1 refresh | Paint, lighting and hardware change how a room feels for the lowest spend. Highest return per rupee. |
| Home is 12 to 20 years old, kitchen and bathrooms are failing | Band 2 partial | Two rooms carry most of the daily irritation and most of the resale objection. |
| Wiring cannot carry air conditioners and geysers; plumbing leaks into the flat below | Band 3 or 4 | This is no longer cosmetic. Deferred, it becomes a claim against you and a hazard. |
| Layout fights the family — no workspace, one bathroom for five people | Band 4, with an engineer | Layout is the expensive part. Decide it once, properly. |
| You are selling within two years | Band 1 or 2 only | Buyers discount a half-finished renovation. A clean, painted, well-lit home sells; a personal-taste rebuild does not return its cost. |
| Rent is cheaper than the interest on a renovation loan | Move, and refresh before you leave | Run the numbers in Chapter 7 before you decide with your feelings. |

Sequence your spending by irritation, not by visibility. The rooms you use every day and the systems that fail quietly deserve the money first. The living room that guests see for twenty minutes a year can wait, and the guest bathroom is almost never the best place for the next lakh.

PART TWO

# The money, before the marble

A renovation budget is not one number. It is a base estimate, a separate contingency, a tax line, and a living-elsewhere line. Homeowners who collapse all four into one figure always overrun, because the contingency gets spent on upgrades long before the surprises arrive.

IN THIS PART

4 Build your own estimate from three quotes
5 The eleven costs nobody puts in the first budget
6 GST, TDS and the tax rules that surprise homeowners
7 Paying for it without paying for it twice

## 4. Build your own estimate from three quotes

Here is the method that replaces every published benchmark. It takes an evening and it will be more accurate than any per-square-foot number you read online, because it is built from your own flat and your own market.

1. Get three itemised quotes for the identical written scope. Identical means the same rooms, the same inclusions, the same exclusions. If a contractor will not itemise, he is out of the comparison — that is the whole test.
2. Rebuild all three into one common bill of quantities. Use the sheet in Part 8. Every line gets a unit, a quantity, a rate and a specification. Where a contractor bundles several items into one line, split it or move that line to "unclear" and ask.
3. Compare line by line, not total by total. The lowest total almost always has a missing heading, not a cheaper way of working. Find the heading: it is usually plumbing, electrical, waterproofing or debris removal.
4. Take the median rate for each line, not the lowest. The lowest rate on a line is usually a rate for a lower specification. Median rate against a specification you chose is the honest number.
5. Add the lines up. That is your base estimate. Now stop and treat it as a floor, not a ceiling.

A word on how the money typically splits, so you can see where a quote is thin. In a full interior renovation, fixed woodwork — wardrobes, kitchen carcass, television unit — is usually the largest single block, often a third to nearly half. Flooring and tiling, electrical, plumbing and sanitary, false ceiling, painting and civil work make up most of the rest. Labour is typically a third to forty per cent of the total in most Indian cities. If a quote has a tiny electrical line or no waterproofing line at all, you have found the

gap.

**Three arithmetic checks that catch inflated quotes**

**The area check.** Divide the quoted total by the carpet area. Then divide it by the built-up area. If the contractor's rate only looks reasonable on super built-up, that is what he is billing you on.

**The wastage check.** Tiles and flooring are quoted with wastage. Ten per cent is normal for a straightforward room, more for diagonal layouts and many cuts. Twenty-five per cent on a plain rectangular floor is padding.

**The quantity check.** Pick the three largest lines and ask for the measurement on which the quantity is based. Ask to see it on the drawing. Chapter 24 gives you the formulas to verify cement, tiles and paint yourself.

## 5. The eleven costs nobody puts in the first budget

These are real, they are common, and they are the reason a project that was quoted at fifteen lakh lands at nineteen. Budget for them on day one and they stop being emergencies.

| Cost | When it appears | How to control it |
|---|---|---|
| Strip-out and debris removal | Week one | Ask for it as a separate line. Old tiles and marble are heavy; carting is priced by the bag or the trip. |
| Society deposit and charges | Before work starts | Ask the society in writing for the deposit, lift protection charge and refund conditions. Deposits are refundable but often deducted from. |
| Rewiring the whole flat | When old wiring is opened | Get an electrician to inspect and quote before demolition, not after. |
| Bathroom rebuilt from the slab | When tiles come off | A failed pond test means the waterproofing membrane goes. Assume it on any bathroom older than fifteen years. |
| Plumbing route changes | When the kitchen moves | Every metre a drain moves is a slope to be built and a slab to be cut. |
| Waterproofing you did not plan | Monsoon, or the first leak below | Specify the system and the pond test in the contract (Chapter 21). |
| Structural repair | After an engineer's inspection | Never priced per square foot. Get it as a separate scope with its own drawings. |
| Living elsewhere | Week two of a band 3 project | Rent, deposit, two moves and storage. Count four to six months for a full renovation. |
| Appliances that no longer fit | Installation week | Measure your existing fridge, washing machine and hob before you fix the carcass dimensions. |
| GST | At invoicing | Confirm in writing whether each quote is inclusive or exclusive, and at what rate. On a fifteen lakh project the difference is large. |
| Snag rectification after handover | The week after you move in | Hold back a final payment until the list is closed (Chapter 14). |

Add these up before you sign anything. Then add a contingency of ten to fifteen per cent of the base estimate, more for a home older than twenty years. Keep the contingency in a separate account, not in the same mental pot as the budget. The moment it shares a pot, it becomes a shutter upgrade.

# 6. GST, TDS and the tax rules that surprise homeowners

Three separate tax questions come up in every renovation. Get them right at the quoting stage and you avoid an argument at invoicing.

## GST on the work itself

Interior and renovation work is generally supplied as a composite works contract — goods and services together, applied to an immovable property — and attracts GST at 18 per cent. Ask every contractor to state, in the quote, whether the rate is inclusive or exclusive of GST and at what rate. "All inclusive" without a tax line beside it is a sentence, not a number.

There is a useful follow-up question in 2026. From 22 September 2025, following the GST Council's 56th meeting, the rate on cement came down from 28 per cent to 18 per cent, and several wood-based products came down from 12 per cent to 5 per cent. If your contractor buys cement and board, the input cost fell. Ask whether the quote reflects it. Some will, some will not, and the ones who will are usually the ones who itemise.

## The home loan trap that catches almost everyone

If you borrow to renovate, the Income Tax Department treats the loan differently from a loan to buy or build. Under section 24(b), interest on capital borrowed to acquire or construct a self-occupied house is deductible up to Rs. 2,00,000 in a year. But interest on capital borrowed for *reconstruction, repairs or renewals* of a self-occupied house is capped at Rs. 30,000. On a let-out property there is no such cap — the whole interest is deductible against the rental income.

The second half of the trap is section 80C. Principal repayment qualifies only for a loan taken to purchase or construct. The cost of any addition, alteration, renovation or repair carried out after the completion certificate or after occupation is expressly not admissible under 80C. So a top-up loan spent on your kitchen gives you a Rs. 30,000 interest deduction at best and no principal deduction at all. Note also that under the new tax regime, the self-occupied interest deduction and 80C are not available; the let-out property interest set-off still is. Confirm your own position with a chartered accountant before you structure the borrowing.

## Cash, and the two lakh line

Section 269ST of the Income-tax Act bars anyone from receiving Rs. 2,00,000 or more in cash from a single person in a day, for a single transaction, or for several transactions relating to one event. The penalty under section 271DA is 100 per cent of the amount received — and it falls on the person who receives it, which in practice means your contractor will pass it back to you. Pay by bank transfer or cheque. It also gives you the payment trail you will need in Chapter 28.

## TDS, if your project is large

Two provisions matter. A person liable to tax audit must deduct tax at source on payments to a contractor — 1 per cent where the payee is an individual or HUF, 2 per cent otherwise. Separately, an individual or HUF who is not liable to deduct under those provisions must deduct 5 per cent under section 194M once aggregate payments for contract or professional work in a financial year exceed Rs. 50,00,000, and file Form 26QD. If your renovation is above fifty lakh, ask your accountant about 194M before the first payment, not after the last.

**The paperwork that pays for itself twice**

Ask for a GST invoice for every payment, with the contractor's GSTIN printed on it. It costs you nothing, it makes the contractor's tax position visible, and it is the single strongest document you can produce if you later have to prove what you paid for in front of a consumer commission.

# 7. Paying for it without paying for it twice

There are four ways to fund a renovation and they differ mainly in what the money costs per year, not in what it costs today.

| Route | Best used for | The question to ask before you take it |
|---|---|---|
| Savings, in stages | Band 1 and 2 work you can phase room by room | Which single room removes the most daily irritation for the least money? |
| Home loan top-up | Band 3 and 4 work on a home you already own a loan against | What is the rate, and is the interest deductible? Remember the Rs. 30,000 cap on a self-occupied repair or renovation loan. |
| Loan against property or securities | Large projects where you want a long tenure | What is the processing fee, and does the lender need a valuation report you will pay for? |
| Personal loan or card EMI | Small top-ups, or bridging a month of cash flow | What is the total interest over the full tenure, not the monthly EMI? |

Two disciplines matter more than the choice of route. First, borrow against a number you built yourself in Chapter 4, not against a contractor's first quote. Second, keep a cash buffer outside the project. Renovations consume cash faster than they consume credit, because material suppliers want payment on delivery and labour wants payment weekly, while your loan disburses on its own schedule.

PART THREE

# Choosing and checking the people

You are about to hand your home and several lakh rupees to someone you met three weeks ago. Almost all of the risk sits in that sentence. The checks in this part are free, take about an hour in total, and eliminate the majority of contractors you should not be dealing with.

IN THIS PART

8 Four ways to buy the work

9 Verify in one hour, for free

10 The reference call that actually works

11 Design fees, and what supervision buys

## 8. Four ways to buy the work

| Model | You get | You pay for | Watch out for |
|---|---|---|---|
| Turnkey firm | One contract, one point of blame, a designer and a site team | A margin on everything, typically 8 to 15 per cent over trade rates | A single rate that hides exclusions. Insist on the itemised BOQ anyway. |
| Designer plus separate contractors | Design and drawings from one person, execution from trades you appoint | A design fee — commonly a percentage of project cost, or a per-square-foot fee | You become the project manager. Budget your own time, honestly. |
| Main contractor with own team | One skilled contractor, direct labour, no designer | Labour plus material, with your approval at each stage | Design decisions land on you. Get drawings made separately. |
| Direct trades, room by room | Lowest cash cost, maximum control | Each trade separately | Sequencing is yours. One trade waiting on another is how a six-week job becomes five months. |

There is no universally correct model. There is only the model that matches how much time you can genuinely spend on site. A turnkey firm costs more and fails less often for people with jobs. Direct trades save money and fail often for people who cannot be present. Decide which person you are before you interview anyone.

Whatever the model, the money question is the same: who is responsible when something is wrong? With four trades on site, the plumber blames the mason, the mason blames the tiler and you pay for all three. Write down, in the contract, who owns the interfaces — waterproofing into tiling, electrical into false ceiling, carpentry into civil.

# 9. Verify in one hour, for free

These five checks are public, free, and take minutes each. A contractor who cannot pass them is not a contractor you should prepay.

| Check | Where | What it tells you |
|---|---|---|
| GST registration | The GST portal's search taxpayer tool, using the GSTIN on the quote | Whether the business is registered, since when, and whether the registration is active or cancelled. Construction services cross the Rs. 20 lakh registration threshold quickly. |
| Udyam / MSME registration | The Udyam registration portal | Whether the enterprise exists as a registered entity. Free to obtain, so absence is a signal. |
| EPFO establishment | The EPFO establishment search | Whether the firm is covered for provident fund. A firm employing ten or more workers should be. |
| Company or LLP status | MCA21 company search | For a private limited or LLP: incorporation date, directors, whether filings are current, whether it is struck off. |
| Product certification | The ISI mark and IS number on the material, checked against the BIS list | Whether the plywood, cable, pipe or tile is certified at all. Chapter 17 to 22 tells you which numbers to ask for. |

Two more checks that are not databases but matter more than any of them. Ask for the address of a project finished in the last twelve months and go there without the contractor. And ask what happens if a shutter delaminates in month nine — the answer tells you whether there is a warranty at all, and whether it is written.

# 10. The reference call that actually works

A reference who says "very good, no problem" has told you nothing. Ask these questions instead, in this order, and listen to the pauses.

1. How long did the work take, against what was promised?
2. How much did the final bill differ from the quote, and what caused the difference?
3. When something went wrong, how quickly did they come back?
4. Did they finish the snag list, or did you give up asking?
5. What would you do differently if you did it again?
6. May I visit the site? — ask this of the reference, not the contractor.
7. Was there any point where you had paid more than the work done?
8. Who paid for the extra material when the quantity ran short?

> **The one answer that ends the conversation**
>
> If a previous client says they paid the final instalment before the snag list was closed and are still waiting, walk away. That is not bad luck. It is how the firm operates.

# 11. Design fees, and what supervision buys

Design fees in India follow three common shapes: a percentage of project cost, usually in the range of 8 to 15 per cent for a full-service engagement; a per-square-foot fee for drawings and consultation; or a lump sum with the margin built into item rates. None is wrong. What matters is what the fee includes.

Ask for these in writing before you pay a design fee: measured drawings of every room, electrical and plumbing layouts, a bill of quantities, material specifications with brands and grades, and a stated number of site visits with supervision included. A design fee that buys drawings but no site visits is half a service — the drawings are the easy part, and the site is where they get built or not built.

Be explicit about the number of revisions included, and what happens after that. "Unlimited revisions" sounds generous and usually means nobody commits to anything. Two rounds before execution and a written variation rate after is a healthier arrangement for both sides.

PART FOUR

# The contract and the bill of quantities

Two documents decide almost every renovation dispute in India: what was written down, and what was priced line by line. Everything else — the handshake, the WhatsApp voice notes, the promise about the shutter finish — is worth very little once the relationship sours.

IN THIS PART

12 Sixteen clauses a renovation contract needs
13 Interrogating a quote: twenty questions
14 Payment: the schedule that protects you
15 Variations: the one-page rule
16 The render that was approved, and the room that arrived

## 12. Sixteen clauses a renovation contract needs

You do not need a lawyer to draft a workable contract, but you do need these clauses. A contract missing four or five of them is the reason the case in Chapter 16 was decided the way it was.

| Clause | What it must say |
|---|---|
| 1. Parties and premises | Full legal names, addresses, GSTIN of the contractor, and the exact address of the flat with the carpet area stated. |
| 2. Scope | The written scope from Chapter 2, attached as an annexure and signed. |
| 3. Bill of quantities | The itemised BOQ, attached, with quantity, unit, rate and specification for every line. |
| 4. Contract price and tax | Total, whether GST is inclusive or exclusive, the rate, and that no other charge applies unless agreed in writing. |
| 5. Payment schedule | Milestones tied to completed work, with a retention amount held to handover. |
| 6. Timeline | Start date, completion date, working hours permitted by the society, and the penalty for delay. |
| 7. Variations | How a change is priced, who authorises it, and that work stops until the variation is signed. |
| 8. Materials | Brand, grade and IS number for each specified item; samples approved in writing; no substitution without written approval. |
| 9. Site rules and safety | Society requirements, debris removal, protection of common areas, insurance and who bears liability for injury on site. |

| Clause | What it must say |
|---|---|
| 10. Sub-contracting | Whether any part may be sub-contracted, and that the contractor remains responsible for sub-contracted work. |
| 11. Warranty | A written warranty period for workmanship and for each material, with what is covered and what voids it. |
| 12. Defects and snag list | The process for listing defects at handover, the rectification window, and what happens if it is missed. |
| 13. Termination | Grounds for termination by either side, notice period, and how work done and materials on site are valued. |
| 14. Dispute resolution | A named forum and seat for arbitration, or an express choice to go to the consumer commission; governing law. |
| 15. Documents at handover | As-built drawings, warranty cards, invoices, test records, and the maintenance instructions. |
| 16. Signatures and date | Signed and dated by both parties, with the annexures initialled on every page. |

Two practical notes. First, a contract on plain paper signed by both sides is a contract; stamp duty rules on works contracts vary by state, so ask locally if the value is large. Second, initial every page of the annexures. Disputes are won and lost on which version of page four was attached.

## 13. Interrogating a quote: twenty questions

Put these to every contractor, in writing, and compare the answers side by side. The answers are more informative than the price.

| # | Question |
|---|---|
| 1 | Is the rate per square foot, and per square foot of which area — carpet, built-up or super built-up? |
| 2 | Is this quote inclusive of GST, and at what rate? |
| 3 | Which items in this quote are excluded, listed completely? |
| 4 | Is strip-out and debris removal included, and where does the debris go? |
| 5 | What is the brand, grade and thickness of the plywood, and its IS number? |
| 6 | What is the laminate or finish brand and thickness, and its IS number? |
| 7 | Which hardware brand, and is it soft-close with a stated warranty? |
| 8 | What is the tile size, finish and price band per square foot, and is wastage included at what percentage? |
| 9 | Is tile adhesive included, and which IS number does it conform to? |
| 10 | What is the waterproofing system in the bathrooms — product, coats, and is a pond test included? |
| 11 | What is the cable brand, size and IS number, and how many points per room? |
| 12 | Is a new distribution board and RCCB included? |
| 13 | What is the pipe brand and schedule for supply and drainage? |
| 14 | What is the paint system — primer, putty, coats — and the brand? |
| 15 | Is false ceiling included, in which rooms, and what is the framework? |
| 16 | What is the payment schedule, and how much is due before work begins? |

| # | Question |
|---|---|
| 17 | What is the retention held back, and until when? |
| 18 | How are variations priced, and at whose rates? |
| 19 | What is the warranty on workmanship, and on each material? |
| 20 | Who is on site daily, and who do I call when something is wrong? |

A contractor who answers all twenty in writing is worth a premium. One who answers eight and says "sab standard hai" is telling you that you will be managing the specification yourself, in the middle of the work, under time pressure. That is the most expensive way to buy anything.

## 14. Payment: the schedule that protects you

Pay for work completed, not for time elapsed. The structure below is conventional, defensible, and keeps the contractor motivated through the least pleasant part of the job — the finishing.

| Stage | Share | Release when |
|---|---|---|
| On signing and material procurement | 20 to 30% | Contract signed, BOQ agreed, first material ordered against your approval |
| On completion of civil and services | 25 to 30% | Demolition done, wiring and plumbing first fix inspected and photographed by you |
| On completion of tiling and ceilings | 20 to 25% | Floors laid, waterproofing pond-tested and passed, false ceiling framed |
| On completion of joinery and painting | 15 to 20% | Wardrobes and kitchen installed, paint finished, hardware working |
| Retention at handover | 5 to 10% | Snag list closed in writing and documents handed over |

Two rules make this work. Never release a stage payment before you have seen the stage — a photograph from the site is not seeing it. And never let the running total of payments exceed the value of work visibly done; the moment it does, you have lost your only lever.

> **On large advances**
>
> A demand for half the contract value before any work starts is not standard practice, it is a cash-flow problem being transferred to you. Where a genuine material advance is needed, pay it against a purchase order in the contractor's name for materials you have approved, and take the invoice.

## 15. Variations: the one-page rule

Change is certain in a renovation. Walls open, a pipe is where the drawing said it was not, a tile is out of stock. What is not certain is the price of the change — unless you fix the process at the start.

The rule is simple and it needs to be in the contract. No variation work begins until a one-page variation note is signed. The note carries four lines: what is changing, the quantity, the rate taken from the original BOQ, and the effect on the completion date. Both parties keep a copy. At the end of the project, the variation notes are added up and that is the final bill.

This single discipline prevents the most common overrun of all: a long tail of small verbal changes that nobody prices until the end, when the total is presented as a fait accompli. If a contractor resists the one-page rule, the resistance is the information you needed.

# 16. The render that was approved, and the room that arrived

In October 2026 the District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission-I at Hyderabad decided a case that every homeowner should read before approving a three-dimensional render. A flat owner engaged an interior company, approved the 3D renders it shared, and received a quotation of about Rs. 12.75 lakh. She paid roughly Rs. 6.10 lakh in December 2023 and a further Rs. 6.35 lakh in March 2024. The work was due to finish by 3 March 2024.

The finished work did not match the approved renders — colours, shutters, cabinet fittings, kitchen units. The company's defence was that the actual work followed separate production drawings and that the renders were illustrative. The commission found that the company had not shown it told her, before she paid or before she approved the renders, that the renders were only indicative. That information came after she raised the mismatch. Collecting payment on that basis, the commission held, was a deficiency in service and an unfair trade practice.

The order directed the company and two associated entities, jointly and severally, to pay Rs. 3,50,000 towards rectification and finishing work, Rs. 50,000 as compensation and Rs. 25,000 towards litigation costs — about Rs. 4.25 lakh in all — within 45 days, with interest at 9 per cent a year on the rectification amount if it was not paid in time.

**What that case teaches, in four lines**

A render is not a specification. Ask for the production drawings, the material list and the BOQ, and make them annexures to the contract.

Put this sentence in the contract: "The approved drawings, material schedule and bill of quantities at Annexures A, B and C form part of this agreement and prevail over any visualisation."

Keep the render, the quotation, every payment proof and every complaint in one folder. The complainant won on documents, not on argument.

Complain early and in writing. The record of when you first objected is often the decisive fact.

PART FIVE

# What to specify, in the language of standards

This part is written as questions you can put to a contractor, because the honest way to buy materials in India is to ask for a standard, not an adjective. "Good quality" is not a specification. An IS number is. The Bureau of Indian Standards mark is the practical test: if a product carries a licence number, the manufacturer has been audited against the standard. Ask to see the pack, not the brochure.

IN THIS PART

17 Civil work: cement, steel, sand, plaster
18 Floors and walls: tiles, stone, adhesives
19 Joinery: plywood, laminates, hardware
20 Electrical and plumbing: the invisible half
21 Waterproofing, ceilings, paint
22 The clause that costs you the specification

## 17. Civil work: cement, steel, sand, plaster

Cement. Ordinary Portland Cement is specified by grade — 33, 43 or 53 — under IS 269, IS 8112 and IS 12269 respectively; Portland Pozzolana Cement is IS 1489. For household work, 43 grade or PPC is common; ask which, and check the bag date. Cement older than about three months loses strength and should not be used structurally. Concrete work should follow IS 456, the code of practice for plain and reinforced concrete.

Steel. Reinforcement should be TMT bars to IS 1786. The grade matters — Fe 415, Fe 500, Fe 500D — and so does the source. Ask for the mill test certificate for any structural steel; a good contractor produces it without being asked twice.

Sand and plaster. Plaster sand is covered by IS 1542. Mortar for masonry and plaster follows IS 2116 and IS 2250, and plaster application practice is IS 1661. Practically: ask what mix ratio is being used for internal plaster and for external plaster, and write the answer into the BOQ. An unstated ratio is how a wall ends up with hollow patches in year two.

The crack question. Ask the contractor what he does at the junction of a concrete column and a brick wall, and around every concealed conduit. The correct answer involves mesh or a bonding treatment, not just plaster. This one detail separates a wall that stays straight from a wall with a hairline crack down

the middle in the first summer.

## 18. Floors and walls: tiles, stone, adhesives

Ceramic and vitrified tiles are specified under IS 15622. Ask for the abrasion class and the water absorption for the room: floors that see outdoor shoes want a low-absorption, higher-abrasion tile; a bathroom floor wants slip resistance, which is a separate property and rarely printed on the box in a showroom.

Adhesive matters more than the tile. Cementitious tile adhesives are specified under IS 15477, and there are classes for different situations. A large-format vitrified tile fixed with a cement-sand mortar bed is a call-back waiting to happen; the correct adhesive class is not an optional upgrade. Ask which class is being used, and for what reason.

Wastage and layout. Agree the layout drawing before ordering, especially for large-format tiles and for any room with a diagonal or herringbone pattern. Ask for the cut plan, and confirm where the cut tiles will land. The single most common complaint about tiling is not the tile, it is a sliver of cut tile running down the middle of a doorway.

Natural stone. Ask for the batch and the slab numbers, and see the actual slabs before they are cut. Stone varies between batches, and "same as the sample" is not enforceable unless the sample is signed and dated.

## 19. Joinery: plywood, laminates, hardware

Plywood. Two standards matter: IS 303 for general-purpose plywood, and IS 710 for marine plywood. In practice the trade talks about MR, BWR and BWP grades. For a kitchen, a bathroom vanity or anywhere that can get wet, specify BWP grade with the IS 710 reference; for dry bedroom wardrobes, BWR is reasonable. Ask for the grade stamp on the sheet, and for the thickness — 18 mm carcass and 6 mm backing are not the same product as 12 mm.

Laminates. Decorative laminated sheets are specified under IS 2046. Ask for the thickness — 0.8 mm and 1 mm behave differently at edges — and for the manufacturer. For a wet area, ask specifically for the moisture-resistant variant. For an acrylic or polyurethane finish, ask what the warranty covers: delamination and yellowing are the two failures, and only one is usually covered.

Hardware. This is where a cheap kitchen announces itself in month eight. Ask for the brand of hinges and channels, whether they are soft-close, and whether the warranty is from the manufacturer or from the carpenter. A manufacturer warranty card in your name is worth more than any verbal assurance.

Edge banding and the inside of the box. Look inside a carcass before you approve the sample. Unbanded edges, exposed screw heads and a bare back panel are the three signs of a wardrobe built to a price. They are invisible from the doorway and they decide how long the piece lasts.

## 20. Electrical and plumbing: the invisible half

Cable. PVC-insulated cables are specified under IS 694. Ask for the brand, the conductor size for each circuit, and whether the cable is FRLS — flame retardant, low smoke. The difference in cost is small; the difference in a fire is not. Ask for the ISI mark on the drum, not on a sample piece.

Protection. A modern flat should have a distribution board with an RCCB or RCBO, and separate circuits for air conditioners, geysers, the kitchen and lighting. Ask how many circuits, and what the rating of each is. If the answer is vague, the wiring is being done to a habit rather than a plan.

Points and positions. Decide furniture positions before the electrician marks points. This is the one sequence error that cannot be fixed cheaply later — a socket behind a wardrobe is a socket you paid for and cannot use.

Pipes. PVC-U pipes for water supply are specified under IS 4985, CPVC under IS 15778, and soil and waste drainage under IS 13592. Ask for the brand and the schedule, and for the pressure rating on the supply line. Ask also how joints are made — solvent cement for CPVC, not thread tape and hope.

The test that proves the plumbing. Before tiling, every supply line should be pressure-tested and every drain should be checked for slope and flow. Ask for the test to be done in your presence and photographed. It takes an hour and it is the difference between a wall that stays closed and one that is opened in year three.

## 21. Waterproofing, ceilings, paint

Waterproofing is the highest-consequence, lowest-visibility item in the whole project. Integral waterproofing compounds are specified under IS 2645; the code of practice for roof waterproofing is IS 3067. In a bathroom, the correct system is a membrane or a specified coating taken up the wall, not merely a compound mixed into the mortar.

The pond test is the only proof. After the waterproofing is laid and before tiling, the floor is flooded and left standing for at least 24 hours, ideally 48, with the level marked. If the level drops or the ceiling below shows damp, the membrane has failed and it is redone. Put the pond test in the contract and photograph it. A bathroom that skips this step is a complaint waiting for the monsoon.

False ceiling. Gypsum board is specified under IS 2095. Ask what the framework is — GI channel at what spacing — and whether the perimeter is fixed with a proper angle section. Ask where the inspection openings will be, because you will need them for the air-conditioner and for the wiring above.

Paint. Ask for the full system, not the topcoat: putty, primer, and how many coats of what. Two coats of emulsion over a skimmed wall and two coats over a patchy one are the same line item and different outcomes. Ask about the moisture content of the plaster before painting — painting damp plaster is how a wall peels in the first monsoon.

## 22. The clause that costs you the specification

"Brand or equivalent." It appears in almost every Indian quote and it quietly gives away everything you just specified. Equivalent to whom, judged by whom, and at what price?

Replace it with a named list. Two acceptable brands, named, with the grade and the IS number. Then add: any substitution requires your written approval, and if the substitution is cheaper, the saving is credited to you. That last sentence is the one that makes the clause real — without it, substitution only ever runs in one direction.

> **The sample rule**
>
> Nothing goes on site that you have not seen a sample of, in your own light, at your own site. Laminate and tile colours read completely differently under a showroom's warm lighting. Approve samples in writing, keep one of each, and label it with the room it belongs to.

PART SIX

# Running the site

A renovation is a sequence, and almost every delay is a sequence error — a trade waiting for another trade, or a decision made after the thing it decides has been built. Learn the order once and you can supervise any project.

IN THIS PART

23 The order of work, and five moments to be present
24 Check the quantities yourself
25 The snag list, and how to close it
26 The handover folder

# 23. The order of work, and the five points where you must be present

| Stage | Work | What you check before it is covered up |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Approvals, society permission, deposit, protection of common areas | Written permission in hand; lift and corridor protected |
| 2 | Demolition and strip-out; debris removal | Nothing structural touched; debris taken to an authorised point, not the empty plot next door |
| 3 | Structural changes, if any, under an engineer | Engineer's written sign-off before any wall is rebuilt |
| 4 | Electrical first fix: conduits, boxes, wiring | Point positions against furniture layout; circuit list; cable brand and size on the drum |
| 5 | Plumbing first fix: supply and drainage, with slope | Pressure test witnessed; drain slopes checked; photographs taken |
| 6 | Waterproofing in wet areas | Pond test for 24 to 48 hours, witnessed and photographed |
| 7 | Plaster, and crack treatment at junctions | Mesh at column and wall junctions; conduit lines covered properly |
| 8 | Tiling and flooring, with adhesive | Adhesive class, layout and cut plan, level and hollow-tile check by tapping |
| 9 | False ceiling framework and boards | Framework spacing, inspection openings, light and AC positions |
| 10 | Joinery: carcass, then shutters, then hardware | Plywood grade stamp, thickness, edge banding, inside of the box |
| 11 | Painting system | Putty dry, primer, coat count, no painting over damp plaster |
| 12 | Fixtures, fittings, appliances, final electrical | Every switch and socket tested; every tap and drain run |
| 13 | Snag walkthrough and handover | The list in Chapter 25, closed in writing |

The five moments to be physically present: the electrical first fix, the plumbing pressure test, the waterproofing pond test, the tile layout before laying, and the joinery carcass before shutters go on. Miss any of those five and you are relying on someone else's memory of what you wanted.

## The society, the neighbours and the three letters nobody sends

In a flat, the society is a third party to your renovation and it has more power over your schedule than the contractor does. Three documents make the difference, and all three are one paragraph long.

1. **The permission letter.** From the society or the resident welfare association, naming the work, the dates, the working hours, the lift to be used and the deposit paid. Without it, a single complaint from a neighbour can stop your site for a week.
2. **The neighbour note.** A short message to the flats immediately above, below and beside you: dates, hours, the contact number of the site supervisor, and an apology in advance for the noise. This one paragraph prevents most of the complaints that would otherwise reach the committee.
3. **The debris route.** In writing, from the society or the local body: where debris may be stored, how it leaves the building, and who is authorised to receive it.

The law has something to say about the debris too. The Environment (Construction and Demolition) Waste Management Rules, 2025, in force from 1 April 2026, put the duty on the waste generator: collect

and segregate the waste into material streams, store it, and hand it to an authorised agency or recycler rather than dumping it. The same rules require demolition to follow IS 4130, the safety code for demolition of buildings, and require the generator to inform the local authority before demolition. In a flat this is mostly about one thing — debris in the wrong place is a fine and a stopped site. Name the authorised destination in the contract, and keep the receipts.

Labour is a separate arrangement from material, and it is worth being deliberate about it. Ask the contractor how the site workers are paid and how often, whether they are covered for injury on site, and who is responsible if someone is hurt in your flat. A firm that employs workers should have provident fund and ESI coverage, which you can check on the EPFO and ESIC establishment searches. Do not let a payment dispute between a contractor and his crew become a stoppage on your project.

## 24. Check the quantities yourself

You do not need to be an engineer to catch a padded quantity. Four checks cover most of the money.

| Item | Rule of thumb | What it catches |
|---|---|---|
| Floor and wall tiles | Measure the actual area from the drawing; add 10 per cent for a plain layout, 15 for diagonal, more for many cuts | Wastage padded to 25 per cent |
| Painting | Multiply the wall area (perimeter times height, less openings) by the number of coats; ask for the coverage printed on the tin | Extra litres billed for a wall that did not need them |
| Plaster and cement | Ask for the mix ratio and the area, and get the bag count from the contractor's own working, then compare with the delivery challans | Bags billed but never delivered |
| Wardrobe and kitchen | Measure in running feet of carcass and in square feet of shutter, and check the unit convention in the BOQ | A line quoted in the unit that flatters the rate |

Then do the one thing almost no homeowner does: count the deliveries. Cement bags, plywood sheets, tile boxes and paint litres arrive with challans. Keep them in a folder, and compare the total at the end with the quantity you were billed for. The gap, when there is one, is usually not theft — it is sloppy bookkeeping on both sides — but it is your money.

## 25. The snag list, and how to close it

Walk the flat room by room, with the contractor present, and write the list down. Date it, number every item, and photograph each one. Give a copy to the contractor and keep the signed original. Then agree a date for closure, in writing.

The list to walk with, room by room:

- Every door and window opens, closes and latches without rubbing; handles and locks work; no gap at the frame.
- Every switch, socket and light works; the RCCB trips when tested; no socket is loose in its box.
- Every tap, mixer and flush runs without a drip; every drain empties without gurgling or standing water; no damp patch on the ceiling below.
- Every tile is level and free of hollow sound when tapped; grout lines are even; no cracked or chipped tile; silicone at every junction is clean.

- Every wardrobe and cabinet door aligns, closes flush, and the soft-close works; no exposed screw heads or unbanded edges inside; drawers run without wobble.
- Paint is even, with no roller marks, no drips on the floor or the fittings, and no visible patch where a wall was opened.
- The kitchen counter is level, the sink is sealed, the chimney duct is connected, and the hob sits flat.
- False ceiling has no sag, no visible joint cracks, and the inspection openings open.
- Site is clean; debris removed; common areas restored; society deposit settled.

> **Retention is your only real guarantee**
>
> Hold back the final five to ten per cent until this list is closed and the documents in Chapter 26 are handed over. A contractor who has been paid in full has no financial reason to return, and the ones who do return are doing it out of goodwill — which is not a warranty.

# 26. The handover folder

Ask for this at handover, in one folder, before the retention is released. It is the difference between owning a renovation and owning a set of problems you cannot diagnose.

1. As-built drawings showing where the wiring and the pipes actually run, marked with dimensions from a fixed wall.
2. The electrical circuit list: which breaker controls what.
3. Warranty cards and invoices for every appliance, fitting and material, in your name where the manufacturer allows it.
4. The tile, laminate, paint and adhesive details with shade or batch codes, so a future repair matches.
5. Waterproofing details: which product, how many coats, which rooms, and the pond test record.
6. Contact details for each trade, for the small fixes that arrive in year two.
7. The maintenance sheet: what to clean with, what not to clean with, where the inspection openings are.

## The first month after you move in

This is when the defects that were always there become visible, and it is also when your leverage is at its highest, because the retention is still unpaid. Do these five things in the first four weeks.

1. Run every tap, flush every drain and fill every basin at least twice a week. Slow drainage shows up in the first fortnight, not in the first year.
2. Check the ceiling below every bathroom and the wall behind every shower for damp patches, tide marks or bubbling paint.
3. Open and close every door, drawer and shutter fifty times. Hardware that is going to fail usually fails early.
4. Test every socket with a small appliance and trip the RCCB deliberately once, so you know it works and know how to reset it.

5 Send the snag list, dated, within thirty days, and keep the acknowledgement. A defect reported in month one is a warranty claim; the same defect reported in month nine is a negotiation.

Keep the handover folder somewhere you will find it in three years, when a tile cracks and you need the batch code. Photograph the folder and store the photographs with your other home documents — it costs nothing and it is the one file you will actually want.

PART SEVEN

# When it goes wrong

Most renovation disputes are resolvable without a lawyer if you escalate in the right order and keep the right paper. Most become expensive because the homeowner waited, complained verbally, and let the two-year clock run.

IN THIS PART

27 The escalation ladder

28 The consumer commission route, precisely

29 Cheques, arbitration, and the notices that work

## 27. The escalation ladder

| Step | What you do | Why it works |
|---|---|---|
| 1. Fix it in writing | A short message listing the defect, the date, the remedy you want and a deadline of seven days. Send it on the channel you have used all along, and keep it. | It creates a dated record. Most disputes end here, because the contractor now knows there is a record. |
| 2. The formal letter | A registered letter or an email to the firm's registered address, setting out the facts in date order, the contract clauses breached, and the amount claimed. | This is the document a commission or an arbitrator reads first. Write it as if a stranger will read it, because one will. |
| 3. Mediation or a pre-litigation settlement | Propose a specific number and a specific date. Offer to split a rectification cost where the fault is genuinely shared. | Cheaper and faster than any forum, and it keeps the contractor motivated to finish. |
| 4. The consumer commission | File a complaint under the Consumer Protection Act 2019, on the national portal, with the documents in Chapter 28. | No lawyer is required to file, the fee is nominal, and it is designed for exactly this kind of deficiency. |
| 5. Civil suit or arbitration | Where the contract names arbitration, or where the claim is outside the consumer route. | Slower and costlier. Take advice before choosing this over step 4. |

## 28. The consumer commission route, precisely

A homeowner who paid for a service and did not get what was promised is a consumer, and a service that falls short is a "deficiency" under the Consumer Protection Act 2019. Interior and renovation work has been held to be a service, and the October 2026 Hyderabad order in Chapter 16 is a recent example of a commission applying it to exactly this kind of work.

Where to file. Jurisdiction follows the consideration paid, under the Consumer Protection (Jurisdiction of the District Commission, the State Commission and the National Commission) Rules, 2021: the District Commission where the value of the goods or services paid as consideration does not exceed Rs. 50 lakh; the State Commission where it exceeds Rs. 50 lakh but not Rs. 2 crore; the National Commission above Rs. 2 crore. Most home renovations sit in the District Commission.

How long you have. Section 69 gives two years from the date the cause of action arose. After that a complaint can still be entertained if you satisfy the commission that you had sufficient cause for the delay, and it records its reasons — but do not plan around condonation.

How to file. Complaints are filed electronically on the national consumer commission portal, with the complaint, a notarised affidavit, an index, a synopsis with a list of dates, and the annexures. The portal workflow requires the complaint to be within the limitation period or accompanied by a condonation application, and matters are listed for admission after scrutiny.

What to attach. This is the part that decides cases:

- The signed contract with every annexure, and the approved drawings, renders and material schedule.
- The itemised quotation and every revised version.
- Every payment proof — bank statements, UPI records, cheque images, GST invoices.
- Photographs dated across the project, including the defects.
- The complete written correspondence: messages, emails, letters, and the contractor's replies.
- Any third-party opinion — an engineer's or an independent contractor's assessment of the cost to rectify.

What you can ask for. Rectification or the cost of it, refund, compensation for loss and mental agony, and litigation costs. In the Hyderabad case the commission awarded a rectification amount, compensation and costs separately, which is the usual structure.

## 29. Cheques, arbitration, and the notices that work

A bounced cheque is a criminal matter, not a civil one, and it has a strict clock. Under section 138 of the Negotiable Instruments Act, 1881, the payee must send a written demand within 30 days of receiving the bank's memo of dishonour, the drawer then has 15 days from receipt of the notice to pay, and a complaint must be filed within one month after that period expires. Miss the 30 days and the remedy is gone. If a contractor pays you a refund by cheque, deposit it immediately and keep the memo if it bounces.

An arbitration clause is not automatically good for you. It removes the dispute from the consumer commission and puts it in front of an arbitrator you may have to pay for. If your contract has one, read it before you sign — and consider whether you would rather keep the commission route open. Where a clause exists, the Arbitration and Conciliation Act, 1996 governs how it runs.

> **A last word on builders and promoters**
>
> If your dispute is with a developer over a flat you bought rather than work done in your home, a different statute applies — the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016 — and the state RERA authority is the forum. A private renovation contract for a home you already occupy is not a real estate project under that Act; it is a consumer service contract.

The notice that works is boring. It is chronological, it is factual, it attaches documents, it states a number, and it gives a date. It does not contain adjectives about the contractor's character. Commissions and arbitrators respond to dates and documents, and the party who has them wins.

PART EIGHT

# Room by room, where the money really goes

Two rooms absorb more of a renovation budget than all the others combined, and they are the two where a centimetre decided early saves a lakh decided late. This part is short and specific on purpose.

IN THIS PART

30 The kitchen, decided in centimetres

31 The bathroom, where water always wins

## 30. The kitchen, decided in centimetres

The kitchen is usually the largest single line in a renovation, and most of the expensive mistakes in it are dimensional rather than decorative. Get these six numbers right before a single carcass is cut.

| Decision | What to fix, and why it matters |
|---|---|
| The work sequence | Sink, hob and refrigerator form the three points you move between. Keep the total run between them short and unobstructed. A fourth point — the bin — is worth planning for. |
| Counter height | Standard is around 850 mm, but the right height depends on who cooks. Test it: stand at the site and place your palms flat. If you have to bend your wrists, the counter is too low. A 50 mm change is cheap now and expensive later. |
| Counter depth and overhang | 600 mm carcass with a small front overhang. Check the overhang against the drawer line — a deep overhang hides the top drawer. |
| The sink | Decide single or double bowl, and the exact model, before the counter is cut. Under-mount sinks need the stone edge polished; that is a workshop job, not a site job. |
| The chimney and the duct | A ducted chimney needs a route to the outside. In a flat with no shaft, this is a hole in a wall, which needs permission. Decide ducted or recirculating before the false ceiling is framed. |
| Appliances and services | Measure the existing refrigerator, washing machine, hob and oven. Note where the water inlet, the drain and the power points must land. An appliance that does not fit a finished carcass is a new appliance. |

Three specification decisions carry the kitchen's life. The carcass plywood should be BWP grade referenced to IS 710 in any zone that can get wet, with the grade stamp visible. The hardware — hinges, channels, lift-ups — should be a named brand with a manufacturer warranty card in your name. And the counter should be specified by material and thickness, not by colour: quartz, granite and solid surface

behave differently at a hot vessel and at a knife edge, and the fabricator's template visit is the moment to confirm the sink and hob cut-outs in writing.

Finally, plan the storage before the shutters. Draw what goes in each cabinet — plates, pressure cooker, masala boxes, the mixer, the large vessel that only comes out at festivals. A kitchen designed around photographs has beautiful elevations and nowhere to put the atta.

## 31. The bathroom, where water always wins

Every bathroom failure in India is one of four things: water going where it should not, a drain that does not fall, air that does not move, or a joint that was sealed with silicone instead of built properly. All four are decided before the first tile is laid.

| Failure | What prevents it |
|---|---|
| Waterproofing that leaks | A specified membrane or coating taken up the wall in the wet zone, applied over a properly prepared, dust-free substrate, cured, and then proved by a pond test of 24 to 48 hours before tiling. Integral compounds to IS 2645 help the mortar; they do not replace the membrane. |
| Standing water on the floor | A slope towards the drain, built into the screed before tiling, of roughly one in a hundred, with the drain at the lowest point. Check it with a spirit level and a bucket of water before the tiles go down. |
| A drain that gurgles or smells | A correct trap and a vented drainage line. Ask what trap is being used and whether the line is vented; a drain with no vent pulls the trap dry and lets the smell back in. |
| Damp on the other side of the wall | Waterproofing on the wet side, not the dry side. Painting a damp wall is decorating a symptom. |
| Mould on the ceiling | Extraction. A ducted exhaust to the outside, or a window that actually opens. A recirculating fan does not remove moisture. |
| A shower that floods the room | A shower area defined by a curb or a slope, with the floor falling to its own drain, not to the room's. |

Two more decisions worth making early. Wall-hung sanitaryware needs a concealed cistern frame built into the wall, which needs depth — check the wall thickness before you fall in love with the design. And floor tiles in a bathroom need slip resistance, which is a separate property from looks; ask for it by name, because the showroom will show you the finish and not the number.

If the bathroom is being rebuilt from the slab, this is also the moment to renew the supply and drainage lines inside the wall. Opening the wall twice — once for the pipe and once, two years later, for the leak — is the most expensive way to do it.

PART NINE

# Worksheets you take to site

Print these six pages, or copy the columns into a notebook. They are deliberately plain: a form you will actually fill in beats a template you admire.

IN THIS PART

W1 The estimate and budget sheet
W2 The contractor scorecard
W3 Comparing three quotes honestly
W4 Payment tracker
W5 Snag list
W6 Handover checklist

## W1. The estimate and budget sheet

One line per BOQ item. Build it from three quotes, take the median rate, then add the four lines at the bottom that are not in anybody's quote.

| Line | Unit | Qty | Rate | Amount | Specification and IS number |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Civil, demolition, debris | | | | | |
| Plaster and crack repair | | | | | |
| Waterproofing (per wet area) | | | | | |
| Flooring and tiling | | | | | |
| Electrical (points, wiring, DB) | | | | | |
| Plumbing (supply, drainage) | | | | | |
| False ceiling | | | | | |
| Joinery — kitchen | | | | | |
| Joinery — wardrobes | | | | | |
| Joinery — other | | | | | |
| Painting | | | | | |
| Fixtures and fittings | | | | | |
| Base estimate | | | | | |

| Line | Unit | Qty | Rate | Amount | Specification and IS number |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| + Contingency (10 to 15%) | | | | | |
| + GST (state rate) | | | | | |
| + Living elsewhere, storage | | | | | |
| + Society deposit and charges | | | | | |
| Total to fund | | | | | |

## W2. The contractor scorecard

Score each contractor out of ten on each line. Anything under 55 total is a no, however good the price.

| Test | 10 means | Score |
|---|---|---|
| Answered the twenty questions in writing | All twenty, with IS numbers | |
| Verified registrations | GSTIN active, Udyam, EPFO, and a company search that is clean | |
| Reference visit | You visited a finished project without the contractor | |
| Itemised BOQ | Every line has a unit, quantity, rate and specification | |
| Payment terms | Milestones on completed work, retention held | |
| Variation process | One-page note, priced at quoted rates | |
| Warranty in writing | Named period for workmanship and for each material | |
| Site presence | A named person is on site daily and reachable | |
| Timeline credibility | Dates you believe, with the society hours built in | |
| Total out of 90 | | |

## W3. Comparing three quotes honestly

Rebuild all three into the same headings. Where a quote has no line for a heading, write "excluded" — do not leave it blank, because blank is how exclusions hide.

| Heading | Quote A | Quote B | Quote C | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Area basis (carpet sq ft) | | | | |
| GST inclusive? | | | | |
| Demolition and debris | | | | |
| Civil and plaster | | | | |
| Waterproofing | | | | |
| Flooring | | | | |
| Electrical | | | | |
| Plumbing | | | | |
| Ceiling | | | | |

| Heading | Quote A | Quote B | Quote C | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Joinery | | | | |
| Painting | | | | |
| Total | | | | |
| Exclusions named | | | | |

## W4. Payment tracker

Keep the running total of payments at or below the value of work you have actually seen. When the two lines cross, stop paying.

| Date | Stage / milestone | Invoice no. | Amount | Paid by | Work seen by me |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| Total paid | | | | | |
| Retention held | | | | | |

## W5. Snag list

Number every item, date the sheet, photograph each one, and get the contractor to sign a copy.

| # | Room | Defect | Photo ref | Agreed remedy | Closed on |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |

# W6. Handover checklist

| Item | Received |
|---|---|
| As-built drawings with pipe and cable routes marked | |
| Electrical circuit list | |
| Warranty cards and invoices, in my name | |
| Tile, laminate, paint and adhesive codes recorded | |
| Waterproofing record and pond test photographs | |
| Trade contact list | |
| Maintenance instructions | |
| Snag list closed and signed | |
| Society deposit settled and common areas restored | |
| Retention released | |

# 40 questions homeowners actually ask

**Short answers, with the chapter that carries the detail.**

| Question | Answer |
|---|---|
| **What should I do first, before calling any contractor?** | Write the scope and the exclusions on one page, and decide which of the five bands you are in. Everything after that is easier, and the first quote you receive will be comparable to the second. Chapter 2. |
| **How many quotes should I get?** | Three, for an identical written scope. Two is a coin toss and four is a week of your life for little extra information. Chapter 4. |
| **Is the cheapest quote a bad sign?** | Not by itself. A quote that is much lower than the others usually has a missing heading — plumbing, electrical, waterproofing or debris removal. Find the heading before you decide. Chapter 4. |
| **Should I pay an advance?** | A material advance against approved materials, with an invoice, is normal. Half the contract value before any work starts is not. Chapter 14. |
| **How much should I hold back at the end?** | Five to ten per cent, released only when the snag list is closed in writing and the handover documents are with you. Chapter 25. |
| **Is GST really 18 per cent on renovation?** | Interior and renovation work is generally a composite works contract and attracts 18 per cent. Confirm in the quote whether the rate is inclusive or exclusive. Chapter 6. |
| **Can I claim the principal on a renovation loan under 80C?** | No. Principal repayment qualifies only for a loan to purchase or construct. The cost of alteration or renovation after occupation is expressly not admissible under 80C. Chapter 6. |
| **Can I claim the interest?** | On a self-occupied house, interest on capital borrowed for reconstruction, repairs or renewals is capped at Rs. 30,000, against Rs. 2,00,000 for acquisition or construction. On a let-out property the interest is deductible without that cap. Chapter 6. |
| **Should I take a top-up on my home loan?** | Often yes for large work, but price the interest over the full tenure and check the tax treatment first. Chapter 7. |
| **Can I pay the contractor in cash?** | Not two lakh rupees or more in one transaction, or in several transactions for one event. The penalty on the recipient is 100 per cent of the amount. Chapter 6. |
| **Do I need to deduct TDS?** | If the project is large, possibly under section 194M once aggregate payments cross Rs. 50,00,000 in a year. Ask your accountant before the first payment. Chapter 6. |
| **Do I need society permission?** | Yes, in writing, before work starts — for the work, the working hours, the lift, the debris route and the deposit. Chapter 5. |
| **Do I need municipal approval?** | For structural alteration, usually yes, and your local building bye-laws decide. For an internal refresh, usually not. Ask your municipal office in writing rather than relying on the contractor's assurance. Chapter 1. |
| **Can I remove an internal wall?** | Only after a structural engineer confirms in writing that it is not load-bearing, and with the society's permission. Chapter 1. |
| **What is a BOQ and why does everyone insist on it?** | A bill of quantities: every item with a unit, a quantity, a rate and a specification. It is the only document on which two quotes become comparable, and the only one you can audit. Chapter 13. |
| **The contractor quotes a per-square-foot rate. Is that fine?** | Only after you know which area it multiplies — carpet, built-up or super built-up — and what is included. Convert it to a BOQ before you compare. Chapter 4. |
| **What does "fully finished" mean?** | Nothing, until it is a list. Replace the phrase every time you hear it. Chapter 2. |

| Question | Answer |
|---|---|
| **How long does a full renovation take?** | It depends on the band: a refresh is weeks, a partial renovation a couple of months, a full interior renovation several months, and a gut rebuild longer. Society working hours and festival weeks stretch any estimate. Chapter 23. |
| **Can I live in the flat during the work?** | For a refresh, yes. For a full renovation, almost nobody manages it comfortably — budget the rent and the two moves. Chapter 5. |
| **How much contingency should I keep?** | Ten to fifteen per cent of the base estimate, more for a home older than twenty years, held separately. Chapter 5. |
| **What is the single most important thing to specify?** | Waterproofing, and the pond test that proves it. It is cheap to do properly and expensive to fix later. Chapter 21. |
| **What is a pond test?** | Flooding the bathroom floor after waterproofing and before tiling, marking the level, and leaving it 24 to 48 hours to see if the level drops or the ceiling below shows damp. Chapter 21. |
| **Which plywood should I use in a kitchen?** | BWP grade, referenced to IS 710, with the grade stamp visible on the sheet. Chapter 19. |
| **Which plywood for bedroom wardrobes?** | BWR is reasonable in dry rooms. Check the thickness of the carcass, not just the grade. Chapter 19. |
| **Why does my laminate peel at the edges?** | Usually thin laminate, poor edge banding or moisture. Specify IS 2046 material, 1 mm where budget allows, and ask what the warranty covers. Chapter 19. |
| **How do I check if a tile is hollow?** | Tap it with a coin or a screwdriver handle after laying. A hollow sound means the adhesive did not cover the back. Check before grouting. Chapter 25. |
| **Is tile adhesive really necessary?** | For large-format and vitrified tiles, yes. Cementitious adhesives are specified under IS 15477 and the class matters for the situation. Chapter 18. |
| **How much tile wastage is normal?** | About 10 per cent for a plain layout, more for diagonal patterns and many cuts. Twenty-five per cent on a plain floor is padding. Chapter 4. |
| **What cable should be used?** | ISI-marked cable to IS 694, in the correct conductor size for each circuit, FRLS where the budget allows. Chapter 20. |
| **Do I need an RCCB?** | A distribution board with an RCCB or RCBO is standard in a modern flat and is the device that protects people rather than appliances. Ask for separate circuits too. Chapter 20. |
| **How many electrical points should I plan?** | Plan furniture first, then points. A socket behind a wardrobe is money spent twice. Chapter 20. |
| **Should I paint before or after the false ceiling?** | Ceiling framework and boards first, then painting, then fixtures. Sequence errors here mean repainting a finished wall. Chapter 23. |
| **How many coats of paint are normal?** | Putty, primer and two coats of the finish is the usual system. Ask for the system, not the topcoat. Chapter 21. |
| **The contractor says "brand or equivalent". Is that acceptable?** | No. Name two acceptable brands with grade and IS number, and require written approval and a credit for any cheaper substitution. Chapter 22. |
| **What if the work is delayed?** | The contract should carry a delay consequence. In practice your leverage is the unpaid stage and the retention, which is why you never pay ahead of work done. Chapter 14. |
| **The work does not match the 3D render. What now?** | Complain in writing immediately and keep the render, the quote and the payments. A commission has held that collecting payment on renders not matching execution is a deficiency in service. Chapter 16. |

| Question | Answer |
|---|---|
| **Where do I file a consumer complaint?** | On the national consumer commission portal. District Commission up to Rs. 50 lakh, State from Rs. 50 lakh to Rs. 2 crore, National above Rs. 2 crore. Chapter 28. |
| **How long do I have to file?** | Two years from the date the cause of action arose. Condonation is possible but not something to rely on. Chapter 28. |
| **Do I need a lawyer for the consumer commission?** | You can file and appear yourself. Many complainants do. Chapter 28. |
| **A cheque from the contractor bounced. What is the deadline?** | Send a written demand within 30 days of the bank's dishonour memo; the drawer has 15 days to pay; file within one month after that. Chapter 29. |

## Sources this playbook relies on

GST Council, 56th meeting recommendations and the PIB FAQ on the rates effective 22 September 2025, including the reduction on cement and select wood-based products; CBIC rate notifications. Income Tax Department, income from house property (section 24(b)) and the note on mode of receipts and payments (sections 269SS, 269ST, 269T and the penalties under 271D, 271DA, 271E); TDS rates for assessment year 2026-27, including sections 194C and 194M. Consumer Protection Act, 2019, including section 69 on limitation; the Consumer Protection (Jurisdiction of the District Commission, the State Commission and the National Commission) Rules, 2021, notified 30 December 2021; the national consumer commission portal workflow published by the National Informatics Centre. Environment (Construction and Demolition) Waste Management Rules, 2025, in force from 1 April 2026, superseding the 2016 rules, including the duty of waste generators and the reference to IS 4130 for demolition. Bureau of Indian Standards specifications cited in Part 5. The District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission-I, Hyderabad order of October 2026 on interior work departing from approved renders, as reported in October 2026. Negotiable Instruments Act, 1881, section 138; Arbitration and Conciliation Act, 1996; Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016. All accessed October 2026.

### One honest caveat

Rules change, state bye-laws differ, and your flat is not a case study. Use this book to ask better questions and to keep better records; take a chartered accountant's view on the tax structure and a lawyer's view before you sign anything large. That is not a limitation of the book — it is how a careful homeowner behaves.